

"the" & "a" Simplified Factor Table

Quick Reference Guide

Factors	The	A, an	Examples
Focus of comment	narrow focus	broad focus	The: Please focus on the tunnel of light. A: France is a nation among many. Possessive: They are our friends.
Group size	small group	big group	A: Please show him a painting. The: Please show him the Van Gogh.
Singular or Plural	plural	single	The: These are the three pens. A: This is a pen.
Number in existence	Only one exists (in the context)	Many exist (in the context)	The: This is the Milky Way Galaxy. A: The is a grain of sand. Possessive: This is your island.
Specialness	Very Special	Not Special	The: Naoto Kan was the prime minister. A: This is a goldfish.
Mentioned already or not	already mentioned	not already mentioned	A: A team of researchers in Belarus... The: The researchers found that....
Countability	Uncountable	Countable	The: I'll have the red house wine, please. The: (specific) May I have the green cup? A: I'll have a cup. Silent "some": I'll have wine.

Table 1: Factors [For using "The" vs. "A" vs. "none" vs. "pronoun" vs. "possessive"]

The rule of the silent "some":

If you can say "some," then you can use **no-word**.

e.g. I am drinking water. = I am drinking **some** water.